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Senior Software Development Engineer in Test (£44,241 - £58,997)

Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency

Apply before 11:55 pm on Sunday 1st November 2026

Driver & Vehicle Licensing Agency

Reference number

482671

Salary

£44,241 - £58,997

The base pay is £44,241. In addition to this the role includes a Digital and Data allowance of up to £14,756.

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Senior Executive Officer

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

DVLA - Information Technology Services

Type of role

Digital
Information Technology

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Job share, Part-time

Number of jobs available

2

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Location

Swansea

About the job

Job summary

Are you experienced in building test automation for both web-based user interfaces and APIs?

Is your attention to detail thorough?

Are you passionate about Software Development Engineer in Test (SDET) principles with a good comprehension of Automation Testing?

If so, we d love to hear from you!

Joining our department comes with many benefits, including:

- Employer pension contribution of 28.97% of your salary. Read more about Civil Service Pensions here
- 25 days annual leave, increasing by 1 day each year of service (up to a maximum of 30 days annual leave), plus 8 bank holidays and a privilege day for the King s birthday
- Flexible working options where we encourage a great work-life balance.

Read more in the Benefits section below!

Find out more about what it's like working at DVLA - Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency Civil Service Careers.

Job description

At the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency (DVLA), we take testing very seriously and we automate as much as we can. Our SDETs are building best-in-class test automation software so that we can build products quickly and safely.

You will be a critical part of a squad following a behaviour-driven design approach (ATDD). You will love to code and to test in equal measure and challenge us to increase the scope of our Continuous Testing.

The DVLA is at the cutting edge of cloud-first technologies. We use Cucumber with Ruby for most of our testing. Our systems under test are usually Dockerised or Serverless applications.

In this dynamic role you will be part of an engineering team accountable for continually driving all aspects of quality improvements. You will be working in one of our delivery teams or as part of the dedicated independent testing team.

Our automation frameworks primarily use Cucumber with Ruby, and the systems we test are typically Dockerised or based on serverless architectures.

This is a dynamic position where you will contribute to an engineering team committed to improving all aspects of software quality. You may work within one of our delivery teams or as part of our dedicated independent testing function.

Your responsibilities will include, but aren t limited to:

- Plan and lead development on sets of related stories
- Coach and mentor more junior colleagues
- Understand and be proficient in different types of testing
- Write clean, maintainable automated testing code

For further information on the role, please read the attached role profile. Please note that the role profile is for information purposes only - whilst all elements are relevant to the role, they may not all be assessed during the recruitment process. This job advert will detail exactly what will be assessed during the recruitment process.

Open Sessions: Would you like to find out more about the role, the team and what it s like to work in our department? If so, we are organising an open session where you can virtually 'meet the team' on the **27th October at 12:30**. Sign up here.

Person specification

Required experience:

You will be comfortable using the Cucumber framework and able to develop expertise in the Ruby programming language to test applications and infrastructure on Platform-as-a-Service environments.

You will bring hands on experience in developing automated tests for web based user interfaces and APIs, with a strong understanding of modern automation practices. You ll proactively apply Continuous Testing principles to accelerate feedback loops across all quality dimensions including security, performance and accessibility by prioritising automation wherever possible.

We re looking for someone who is deeply passionate about SDET principles, with a solid grasp of automation testing techniques and the ability to use modern programming languages to validate and automate tests for any software product.

You ll be able to demonstrate how you have previously improved quality engineering efficiency through automation, tooling, and process enhancements. Strong attention to detail is essential, along with the confidence to challenge assumptions and drive best practice across teams.

Experience in technical coaching or mentoring would be highly valuable, and we d welcome someone who enjoys supporting and guiding junior engineers as they grow.

Additional Information

The role is part of the Government Digital and Data and utilises an enhanced Capability Based Pay Framework which provides access to a Digital and Data allowance.

The base pay is £44,241. In addition to this the role includes a Digital and Data allowance of up to £14,756.
The value of allowance awarded will be based on an assessment of your skills and experience as demonstrated through the selection process. Here are more details on the pay framework.

Working for the DVLA Digital Team

At DVLA, licensing is just the start. Every project you implement, touch and deliver has a ripple effect that ll wash across the nation. Here the work you re doing has the capacity to change the way 53 million people interact with our services. As we aim to keep our roads some of the safest in the world, our innovative, transformative digital-led services help optimise a nation of individuals and business every single day.

To see how our people are transforming our digital services, head over to our DVLA Digital Services Blog and, to understand more about the great opportunities and benefits of working at DVLA read our Inside DVLA blog.

Working hours, office attendance and travel requirements

Full time roles consist of 37 hours per week. Whilst we welcome applications from those looking to work with us on a part time basis, there is a business requirement for the successful candidate to be able to work at least **35** hours per week.

This role **is suitable** for hybrid working, which is a non-contractual arrangement where a combination of workplace and home-based working can be accommodated subject to business requirements.

The expectation at present is a minimum of **60%** of your working time a month will be spent at either your designated workplace (one of the locations cited in the advert) or, when required for business reasons, in another office/ work location. There may be occasions where you are required to attend above the minimum expectation.

If you have a question about hybrid working, part time/job share hours, flexible working, or require a reasonable adjustment, please contact the Vacancy Holder during the recruitment process to avoid possible disappointment later in the process should your working arrangements not be compatible with the requirements of the role (see below for contact details).

Security Check

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is security check. To allow for meaningful checks to be carried out, candidates will be required to have at

least 5 years continuous residency in the UK. All applicants for this role must ensure that they meet this minimum residency requirement - if you do not, your application will be withdrawn.

Visa Sponsorship

Please note that we do not hold a UK Visa & Immigration (UKVI) Skilled Worker Licence sponsor and are unable to sponsor any individuals for Skilled Worker Sponsorship. Candidates must ensure they have the appropriate rights to work in the UK before application.

Behaviours

We'll assess you against these behaviours during the selection process:

Communicating and Influencing

Technical skills

We'll assess you against these technical skills during the selection process:

Modern Development Standards (Practitioner)

Programming and Build (Software Engineering) (Practitioner)

Prototyping (Practitioner)

User Focus (Practitioner)

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £44,241, Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency contributes £12,816 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides (opens in a new window).

Passionate, reliable and always willing to push yourself and those around you, you ll continue to seek improvement in your own role and challenge us too. Because we pride ourselves on how we approach your development. From training courses to specialist skills workshops and opportunities to grow your

expertise, we thrive when you thrive. You can find out more about all of the above here alongside a full list of our benefits:

- Best in class learning and development tailored to your role
- An environment with flexible working options where we encourage a great work-life balance
- A culture encouraging inclusion and diversity with a range of staff communities to support all our colleagues
- Generous employer contribution of 28.9%, depending on chosen pension scheme
- Flexible working options where we encourage a great work-life balance.
- Digital communities with clear career frameworks
- On-site gym plus personal training available (membership applies)
- On-site nursery, restaurants and coffee bar
- 25 days holiday (plus bank holidays), increasing by 1 each year (up to 30) & 8 Bank Holidays plus an additional Privilege Day to mark the King s birthday.
- 24-hour Employee Assistance Programme providing free confidential help and advice for staff.
- Free parking

Find out more about the benefits of working at DfT and its agencies (opens in a new window).

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our candidate guidance (opens in a new window) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

This vacancy is using Success Profiles (opens in a new window), and will assess your Behaviours, Experience and Technical skills.

How to apply:

Our selection process ensures a comprehensive assessment of each applicant's skills, and potential fit within our organisation.

The selection process for this role will be:

Stage 1: Sift of CV and personal statement

Stage 2: Coding Exercise

Stage 3: Interview

You must be successful at each stage to progress to the next stage.

Stage 1: Sift

At sift, you will be assessed against the following Success Profile element:

Experience you will be asked to provide a CV (unlimited wordcount) and personal statement (750-word count).

Please provide evidence of your Experience of the following:

- Experience in development using recognised programming languages
- Demonstrable experience of automation testing
- Practical experience of CI/CD (Continuous Integration and Continuous Deployment)

The sift will take place week commencing 02/11/2026.

Should we receive a high volume of quality applications, we may invite a shortlist of the highest scoring candidates to interview. This means that some applications that meet the required standard could be placed on hold after the sift and invited to interview if the vacant position(s) remain unfilled. You will be notified if your application is being put on hold once the sift has been

completed. Following interviews, any applicants remaining on hold will be notified by the panel of the next steps regarding their application.

Stage 2: Coding Exercise

If at sift your application is successful, you will be invited to the first stage of the interview process where you will be asked to complete a Coding Exercise. The coding exercise will be based on the technical skills Programming and Build (Software Engineering) and Prototyping; both at Practitioner level. Guidance will be provided if you are successful at sift stage.

The coding exercise will take place week commencing 16/11/2026.

Stage 3: Interview

At interview stage, you will be assessed against the following Success Profile elements:

Behaviours

Communicating & Influencing

Technical

Modern Development Standards (Practitioner)

Programming and Build (Software Engineering) (Practitioner)

Prototyping (Practitioner)

User Focus (Practitioner)

Guidance will be provided if you are invited to interview.

The interviews will take place week commencing 30/11/26.

This interview will be conducted in person at our DVLA Swansea office (Longview Road, SA6 7JL). Further details will be provided to you should you be selected for interview.

Appointments for this position will be made in order of merit. If you are successful in the selection process but there are no further available posts for the advertised role, you may be contacted to discuss an offer for a lower graded role (with similar experience and responsibility requirements). If you

are unsuccessful in the selection process, your application may be considered for a lower graded position if your demonstrated skills and experience meet the requirements of the alternative position. Candidates will be considered in order of merit.

You can find out more about our hiring process, how to apply, and application and interview guidance on our careers site (opens in a new window).

Please note that we will try to meet the dates set out in the advert. There may be occasions when these dates will change.

Further information on the selection process

We will also hold a 12-month reserve list for this role, which may lead to potential opportunities beyond the role you applied for.

Reasonable Adjustments

As a Disability Confident Leader employer, we are committed to ensuring that the recruitment process is fair, accessible and allows all candidates to perform at their best. If a person with a visible or non-visible disability is substantially disadvantaged, we have a duty to make reasonable changes to our processes.

Complete the Assistance required section in the Additional requirements page of your application form to tell us what changes or help you might need during the recruitment process. For instance, you may need wheelchair access at an interview, or if you re deaf, a Language Service Professional.

If you need a reasonable adjustment so that you can complete your application, you should contact Government Recruitment Service via dftrecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk as soon as possible before the closing date to discuss your needs.

Document Accessibility

This job advert contains links to the DfT Careers website. Our website provides useful guidance and information that can support you during the application process. If you are experiencing accessibility problems with any

attachments on this advert or the information on our website, please contact the email address in the 'Contact point for applicants' section.

Further Information

For more information about how we hire, and for useful tips on submitting your application for this role, visit the How We Hire page of our DfT Careers website. You can find detailed information about the recruitment process and what to expect when applying for a role.

If your application is successful but you have been dismissed from the Civil Service, your application could be removed at the pre-employment checking stage depending on the nature of the dismissal.

Applicants who are successful at interview will be, as part of pre-employment screening, subject to a check on the Internal Fraud Database (IFD). This check will provide information about employees who have been dismissed for fraud or dishonesty offences. This check also applies to employees who resign or otherwise leave before being dismissed for fraud or dishonesty had their employment continued. Any applicant s details held on the IFD will be refused employment. A candidate is not eligible to apply for a role within the Civil Service if the application is made within a 5-year period following a dismissal for carrying out internal fraud against government.

All external applicants and current employees of accredited non-departmental public bodies (NDPBs) will be required to undergo a Social Media Check. A Social Media Check is a review of your publicly available online activity, typically across platforms like LinkedIn, Facebook, X (formerly Twitter), Instagram, and others. The purpose is to identify any public posts or content that could raise concerns for employers, such as:

- Hate speech or discriminatory behaviour
- Threats or acts of violence
- Illegal activity or substance misuse
- Sexually explicit material
- Extremist views or affiliations

Importantly, this check does not involve hacking into your accounts or accessing private messages. It only considers content you have chosen to make public. Employers use this kind of screening to help ensure their

workplace remains safe, inclusive, and aligned with company values. It s not about judging your personality or lifestyle - it s about checking for potential red flags that might affect the role or company culture. If you have questions or concerns about the social media check, we would be happy to explain in more detail what s being looked at and how your data is handled securely and fairly.

For further information on National Security Vetting please visit the Demystifying Vetting website.

Feedback

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a basic (or equivalent) criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is security check (opens in a new window).

See our vetting charter (opens in a new window).

People working with government assets must complete baseline personnel security standard (opens in new window) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals
- nationals of the Republic of Ireland
- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status

under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS) (opens in a new window)

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)

individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020

Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

Further information on nationality requirements (opens in a new window)

Working for the Civil Service

The Civil Service Code (opens in a new window) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's recruitment principles (opens in a new window).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan (opens in a new window) and the Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy (opens in a new window).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the Great Place to Work for Veterans (opens in a new window) initiative.

The Civil Service welcomes applications from people who have recently left prison or have an unspent conviction. Read more about prison leaver recruitment (opens in new window).

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : ITS Recruitment

Email : ITSRecruitment@dvla.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : dftrecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk

Further information

If you feel your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles and you wish to make a complaint, in the first instance, you should contact Government Recruitment Services via email: dftrecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk If you are not satisfied with the response you receive from the Department, you can contact the Civil Service Commission: Click here (https://civilservicecommission.independent.gov.uk/) to visit Civil Service Commission

Civil Service Commission

disability confident LEADER